

# Word family: \*\*neck / necks / necked / necking\*\*

\*\*Base word:\*\* neck

\*\*Part of speech:\*\* mainly \*\*noun\*\*, also \*\*verb\*\*

\*\*Related forms:\*\*

\* \*\*neck\*\* (n.) — 頸；頸部；瓶頸 / 細長部分；衣領開口；壓力來源

\* \*\*neck\*\* (v.) — 親熱接吻；把.....的頸部處理掉 / 掐頸（較少見或專門）

\* \*\*necking\*\* (n.) — 親熱接吻

\* \*\*neckline\*\* (n.) — 領口線；領口款式

\* \*\*neckwear\*\* (n.) — 頸部配飾

\* \*\*bottleneck\*\* (n./v.) — 瓶頸；造成瓶頸

\*\*Useful expressions / extensions:\*\*

\* \*\*neck pain\*\*

\* \*\*back of the neck\*\*

\* \*\*neck of a bottle\*\*

\* \*\*neck of land\*\*

\* \*\*neckline\*\*

\* \*\*crew neck\*\*

\* \*\*V-neck\*\*

\* \*\*bottleneck\*\*

\* \*\*pain in the neck\*\*

\* \*\*stick your neck out\*\*

\* \*\*risk your neck\*\*

\* \*\*save someone's neck\*\*

\* \*\*up to your neck in\*\*

\* \*\*breathing down someone's neck\*\*

\* \*\*neck and neck\*\*

\* \*\*neck of the woods\*\*

\* \*\*get it in the neck\*\*

\* \*\*break your neck to do something\*\*

\* \*\*necking\*\*

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## Meaning in this passage

> The deadline was \*\*breathing down our necks\*\*, so everyone was tired, tense, and a little irritable.

Here, \*\*neck\*\* is part of the idiom:

### \*\*breathe down someone's neck\*\* = 逼得很緊；緊迫地監視 / 催促某人\*\*

The image is of someone standing so close behind you that you can almost feel their breath on your neck.

**\*\*中文翻譯：\*\***

截止日期已經**\*\*逼在我們眼前 / 緊緊追着我們\*\***，所以大家都很累、很緊張，也有點容易煩躁。

So here:

#### **\*\*neck = idiomatic body-part image used to express pressure and lack of personal space\*\***

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# 1. **\*\*neck ( 頸 ; 頸部 ) — 頸 ; 脖子\*\***

This is the core literal sense.

#### Practice 1

> My **\*\*neck\*\*** hurts after sitting at the desk all day.

我整天坐在書桌前，現在**\*\*頸很痛\*\***。

#### Practice 2

> She wore a scarf around her **\*\*neck\*\***.

她在**\*\*頸上\*\***圍了一條圍巾。

#### Practice 3

> He turned his **\*\*neck\*\*** slowly.

他慢慢轉動**\*\*頸部\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*neck = the part of the body that connects the head to the shoulders\*\***

#### 中文：

**\*\*連接頭部和肩膀的身體部位\*\***

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# 2. **\*\*back of the neck — 後頸\*\***

#### ### Practice 1

> I felt a pain at the \*\*back of my neck\*\*.

我感到\*\*後頸\*\*疼痛。

#### ### Practice 2

> The sun burned the \*\*back of his neck\*\*.

太陽曬傷了他的\*\*後頸\*\*。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*back of the neck = 頸部後方的位置\*\***

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#### # 3. \*\*neck pain / stiff neck — 頸痛 / 頸部僵硬\*\*

#### ### Practice 1

> Poor posture can cause \*\*neck pain\*\*.

姿勢不好可能引致\*\*頸痛\*\*。

#### ### Practice 2

> I woke up with a \*\*stiff neck\*\*.

我起床時發現\*\*頸部很僵硬\*\*。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*stiff neck = 頸部肌肉僵硬、難以轉動的狀態\*\***

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#### # 4. \*\*neck ( 瓶頸 / 細長部分 ) — 頸部 ; 細窄部分\*\*

A major shape-based extension.

#### ### Practice 1

> Hold the bottle by the \*\*neck\*\*.

拿住瓶子的\*\*瓶頸位置\*\*。

#### ### Practice 2

> The **neck of the bottle** is very narrow.

這個瓶子的**瓶頸**很窄。

**MCQ-ready definition:**

**neck = an object's narrow part connecting a wider part to another section**

### 中文：

**物件中像頸一樣較窄、連接兩部分的位置**

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# 5. **neck of a bottle — 瓶頸**

#### ### Practice 1

> The label goes around the **neck of the bottle**.

標籤圍在**瓶頸**位置。

#### ### Practice 2

> The cork was stuck in the **neck of the bottle**.

軟木塞卡在**瓶頸**。

**MCQ-ready definition:**

**neck of a bottle = 瓶身上方通向瓶口的狹窄部分**

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# 6. **neck ( 地理：狹長地帶 ) — 狹長地帶；地峽**

#### ### Practice 1

> The village sits on a narrow **neck of land**.

村莊位於一片狹窄的**地帶 / 地峽**上。

#### ### Practice 2

> A thin **neck of land** connects the peninsula to the mainland.

一條狹窄的\*\*陸地帶\*\*把半島和大陸連接起來。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*neck of land = 一段狹窄、連接兩個較大陸地區域的土地\*\***

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# 7. **\*\*neck (衣服領口) — 領口 ; 領型\*\***

A clothing sense.

### Practice 1

> She wore a dress with a high **\*\*neck\*\***.

她穿了一條**\*\*高領\*\***裙。

### Practice 2

> I prefer shirts with a loose **\*\*neck\*\***.

我較喜歡**\*\*領口較鬆\*\***的恤衫。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*neck = the opening of a garment around the neck\*\***

### 中文：

**\*\*衣服圍繞頸部的開口或領口部分\*\***

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# 8. **\*\*V-neck — V 領\*\***

### Practice 1

> He wore a **\*\*V-neck sweater\*\***.

他穿了一件**\*\*V 領冷衫\*\***。

### Practice 2

> She prefers **\*\*V-neck tops\*\***.

她較喜歡**\*\*V 領上衣\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*V-neck = 衣服前方呈 V 形的領口設計\*\***

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# 9. **\*\*crew neck — 圓領\*\***

#### Practice 1

> He bought a **\*\*crew-neck T-shirt\*\***.

他買了一件**\*\*圓領 T 恤\*\***。

#### Practice 2

> This sweater has a **\*\*crew neck\*\***.

這件冷衫是**\*\*圓領\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*crew neck = 接近頸部、呈圓形的領口設計\*\***

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# 10. **\*\*neckline — 領口線；領口款式\*\***

#### Practice 1

> The dress has an elegant **\*\*neckline\*\***.

這條裙的**\*\*領口線條\*\***很優雅。

#### Practice 2

> Different **\*\*necklines\*\*** suit different styles.

不同的**\*\*領口款式\*\***適合不同風格。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*neckline = 衣服在頸部和胸前的領口形狀與線條\*\***

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# 11. **\*\*bottleneck — 瓶頸；障礙\*\***

A major figurative extension from bottle neck.

#### ### Practice 1

> Traffic creates a **bottleneck** near the bridge.

橋附近的交通形成了一個**瓶頸**。

#### ### Practice 2

> Lack of staff became a major **bottleneck**.

人手不足成為一個主要**瓶頸** / 阻礙。

**MCQ-ready definition:**

**bottleneck = a narrow or limiting point that slows down movement, work, or progress**

### 中文：

**限制流程、令事情變慢的狹窄或受阻環節**

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# 12. **bottleneck traffic / production — 交通 / 生產瓶頸**

#### ### Practice 1

> The tunnel is a traffic **bottleneck**.

隧道是一個交通**瓶頸**。

#### ### Practice 2

> Packaging became the production **bottleneck**.

包裝工序成為生產**瓶頸**。

**MCQ-ready definition:**

**bottleneck = the slowest or most restrictive part of a system**

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# 13. **pain in the neck — 很煩的人 / 事**

A very common informal idiom.

### ### Practice 1

> Filling in all these forms is a real **\*\*pain in the neck\*\***.

填這麼多表格真的**\*\*很麻煩\*\***。

### ### Practice 2

> That broken printer is becoming a **\*\*pain in the neck\*\***.

那部壞打印機愈來愈**\*\*令人煩惱\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*pain in the neck = informal: an annoying person, task, or situation\*\***

### 中文：

**\*\*令人很煩、很麻煩的人或事\*\***

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# 14. **\*\*breathe down someone's neck — 緊迫監視 / 催促；逼得很緊\*\***

This is the exact idiom used in your passage.

### ### Practice 1 — original sentence

> The deadline was **\*\*breathing down our necks\*\***.

截止日期**\*\*逼得我們很緊\*\***。

### ### Practice 2

> I can't work properly with my manager **\*\*breathing down my neck\*\***.

經理一直**\*\*在旁邊緊迫監督我\*\***，我根本無法好好工作。

### ### Practice 3

> We had inspectors **\*\*breathing down our necks\*\*** all week.

整個星期都有檢查人員**\*\*緊緊盯着我們\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*breathe down someone's neck = stand metaphorically very close to someone by watching, pressuring, or demanding progress\*\***

#### 中文：

**\*\*不斷監督、催促或施壓，令人感到被緊迫盯住\*\***

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# 15. **\*\*stick your neck out — 冒險表態；冒險幫人\*\***

A major idiom.

#### Practice 1

> She **\*\*stuck her neck out\*\*** to defend her teammate.

她為了替隊友辯護而**\*\*冒險挺身而出\*\***。

#### Practice 2

> I'm not willing to **\*\*stick my neck out\*\*** without more information.

沒有更多資料，我不願意**\*\*冒這個險\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*stick your neck out = take a personal risk by supporting someone, expressing an opinion, or taking responsibility\*\***

#### 中文：

**\*\*為某人或某事冒個人風險，公開表態或承擔責任\*\***

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# 16. **\*\*risk your neck — 冒生命 / 重大風險\*\***

#### Practice 1

> Don't **\*\*risk your neck\*\*** for something so minor.

不要為這麼小的事**\*\*冒大險\*\***。

#### Practice 2

> The rescuers **\*\*risked their necks\*\*** to help people.

救援人員為幫助別人而**\*\*冒着生命危險\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*risk your neck = put yourself in serious danger\*\***

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# 17. **\*\*save someone's neck — 救某人一把；使某人免於麻煩\*\***

#### Practice 1

> Your help really **\*\*saved my neck\*\***.

你的幫忙真的**\*\*救了我一把\*\***。

#### Practice 2

> That extra copy **\*\*saved his neck\*\*** when the original disappeared.

原件不見時，那份副本真的**\*\*幫他逃過一劫\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*save someone's neck = prevent someone from suffering serious trouble, punishment, or failure\*\***

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# 18. **\*\*up to your neck in something — 深陷於；忙得不可開交\*\***

#### Practice 1

> I'm **\*\*up to my neck in work\*\***.

我現在**\*\*工作多得忙不過來\*\***。

#### Practice 2

> They were **\*\*up to their necks in debt\*\***.

他們**\*\*債台高築 / 深陷債務\*\***。

**\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\***

**\*\*up to your neck in X = deeply involved in, overwhelmed by, or surrounded by X\*\***

#### 中文：

**\*\*深陷某種情況，程度很深而難以輕鬆脫身\*\***

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# 19. \*\*neck and neck — 不相上下；並駕齊驅\*\*

A major figurative expression.

### Practice 1

> The two runners were \*\*neck and neck\*\*.

兩名跑手\*\*不相上下\*\*。

### Practice 2

> The two teams remained \*\*neck and neck\*\* until the end.

兩隊一直到最後都\*\*勢均力敵\*\*。

\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\*

\*\*neck and neck = at almost exactly the same level or position in a competition\*\*

### 中文：

\*\*比賽或競爭中雙方幾乎完全並列\*\*

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# 20. \*\*neck of the woods — 某個地區；一帶\*\*

Informal.

### Practice 1

> What brings you to this \*\*neck of the woods\*\*?

甚麼風把你吹到\*\*這一帶\*\*？

### Practice 2

> There aren't many restaurants in this \*\*neck of the woods\*\*.

\*\*這一帶\*\*沒有很多餐廳。

\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\*

\*\*neck of the woods = informal: a particular area or neighbourhood\*\*

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# 21. \*\*get it in the neck — 被責罵 / 受罰 / 倒霉\*\*

Especially BrE informal.

### Practice 1

> I'll \*\*get it in the neck\*\* if I'm late again.

如果我再遲到，我肯定會\*\*被鬧 / 受罰\*\*。

### Practice 2

> He \*\*got it in the neck\*\* for the mistake.

他因為那個錯誤而\*\*被狠狠責備\*\*。

\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\*

\*\*get it in the neck = BrE informal: be criticized, punished, or suffer because of something\*\*

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# 22. \*\*break your neck to do something — 拼命 / 非常努力做某事\*\*

Informal.

### Practice 1

> I \*\*broke my neck to finish the report\*\* on time.

我為了準時完成報告，幾乎\*\*拼了命地趕\*\*。

### Practice 2

> Don't \*\*break your neck trying to impress everyone\*\*.

不要為了令所有人滿意而\*\*拼命過頭\*\*。

\*\*MCQ-ready definition:\*\*

\*\*break your neck to do X = informal: make an extremely strong effort to do X\*\*

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# 23. \*\*neck ( verb : 親熱接吻 ) — 親熱 ; 擁吻\*\*

Informal, somewhat old-fashioned.

#### ### Practice 1

> The couple were **necking** in the back row.

那對情侶在後排**親熱擁吻**。

#### ### Practice 2

> They spent the evening **necking** in the car.

他們整晚在車裏**親熱接吻**。

**MCQ-ready definition:**

**neck = informal: kiss and embrace romantically for a period of time**

This is useful mainly for recognition; it is less common in modern neutral speech.

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# 24. **necking** — 親熱；擁吻

#### ### Practice 1

> The old film used the word **necking** for kissing and cuddling.

那套舊電影用 **necking** 表示**親熱接吻**。

#### ### Practice 2

> The term **necking** can sound old-fashioned today.

**Necking** 現在聽起來可能有點老派。

**MCQ-ready definition:**

**necking = informal romantic kissing and embracing**

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# Important distinction 1: **neck vs throat**

Very important.

### **neck**

external body part connecting head and shoulders.

### \*\*throat\*\*

internal/front passage involved in swallowing and speaking.

> neck pain

頸痛

> sore throat

喉嚨痛

Do not use \*\*neck\*\* for ordinary throat pain.

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# Important distinction 2: \*\*neck vs shoulder\*\*

### \*\*neck\*\*

between head and torso.

### \*\*shoulder\*\*

upper side of torso where arm joins body.

> scarf around your neck

> bag over your shoulder

Different body parts.

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# Important distinction 3: \*\*neck = body part vs neck = narrow section\*\*

The object sense is based on shape.

> human neck

人體頸部

> bottle neck

瓶頸部位

The semantic extension is very direct: **\*\*a narrow connector between wider parts\*\***.

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# Important distinction 4: **\*\*bottleneck literal vs figurative\*\***

### Literal origin

the narrow neck of a bottle.

### Figurative

the narrowest/slowest point in a process.

> traffic bottleneck

交通瓶頸

> production bottleneck

生產瓶頸

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# Important distinction 5: **\*\*breathe down someone's neck vs watch someone\*\***

### **\*\*watch someone\*\***

neutral.

### **\*\*breathe down someone's neck\*\***

strongly implies intrusive pressure or close supervision.

> My manager watched me.

經理看着我。

> My manager was breathing down my neck.

經理**\*\*盯得我很緊、催得我透不過氣\*\***。

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# Important distinction 6: **\*\*deadline breathing down your neck\*\***

Here, a **deadline** is personified.

The deadline obviously cannot literally breathe.

The image means:

### **the deadline is so close that it feels physically present behind you**

So:

> deadline breathing down our necks

>  $\approx$  looming deadline + intense pressure

but more vivid.

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# Important distinction 7: **stick your neck out vs risk your neck**

### **stick your neck out**

take a social/professional/personal risk.

### **risk your neck**

may imply serious physical danger.

> stick your neck out for a colleague

冒險替同事說話

> risk your neck climbing a cliff

攀崖時冒生命危險

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# Important distinction 8: **save your neck vs save your life**

### **save your life**

literally prevent death.

### **save your neck**

often figurative: prevent trouble, punishment, failure.

> That backup saved my neck.

那個備份救了我一把。

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# Important distinction 9: **\*\*up to your neck in vs busy\*\***

### **\*\*busy\*\***

simply has a lot to do.

### **\*\*up to your neck in\*\***

much stronger; overwhelmed or deeply involved.

> busy with work

工作忙

> up to my neck in work

忙到不可開交

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# Important distinction 10: **\*\*neck and neck vs equal\*\***

### **\*\*equal\*\***

same value/status generally.

### **\*\*neck and neck\*\***

specifically emphasizes an ongoing close competition.

Two runners can be neck and neck for most of a race.

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# Important distinction 11: **\*\*neck of the woods\*\***

This does not refer to trees or an actual neck.

It is a fixed informal expression meaning:

### \*\*某個地區 / 這一帶\*\*

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# Important distinction 12: \*\*pain in the neck vs neck pain\*\*

Completely different.

### \*\*neck pain\*\*

頸痛

### \*\*a pain in the neck\*\*

很煩的人 / 事

> My neck pain is getting worse.

我的頸痛加劇。

> This paperwork is a pain in the neck.

這些文書工作真麻煩。

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# Important distinction 13: \*\*break your neck literal vs idiomatic\*\*

### Literal

serious neck injury.

### Idiomatic

make an extreme effort.

> He broke his neck in the accident.

他意外中頸部重傷。

> He broke his neck to finish the work.

他拼命趕完工作。

Context is critical.

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# Important distinction 14: **necking** is not simply “using your neck”

As a verb, **neck** has a lexicalized romantic sense:

### **kiss and embrace**

This is unrelated to most modern noun uses and should be recognized as a separate branch.

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# Family-extension note

**Neck** has several major modern branches:

### 1. **body part**

- \* neck
- \* back of the neck
- \* neck pain

### 2. **narrow connecting part**

- \* neck of a bottle
- \* neck of land

### 3. **clothing**

- \* neckline
- \* V-neck
- \* crew neck

### 4. **system constraint**

- \* bottleneck

### 5. **pressure and risk idioms**

- \* breathe down someone's neck
- \* stick your neck out
- \* risk your neck
- \* save your neck
- \* up to your neck

#### ### 6. \*\*competition\*\*

\* neck and neck

#### ### 7. \*\*area\*\*

\* neck of the woods

#### ### 8. \*\*effort/punishment idioms\*\*

\* break your neck to

\* get it in the neck

#### ### 9. \*\*verb\*\*

\* neck / necking = 親熱接吻

The figurative expressions often exploit the idea that the neck is a **vulnerable, exposed part of the body**, which makes it a natural metaphor for pressure, risk, and danger.

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#### # Master comparison

| Form / expression                  | Traditional Chinese | Core idea            |  |
|------------------------------------|---------------------|----------------------|--|
| -----                              | -----               | -----                |  |
| <b>neck</b>                        | 頸；脖子                | body part            |  |
| <b>back of the neck</b>            | 後頸                  | body location        |  |
| <b>stiff neck</b>                  | 頸部僵硬                | physical condition   |  |
| <b>neck of a bottle</b>            | 瓶頸                  | narrow part          |  |
| <b>neck of land</b>                | 狹長地帶 / 地峽           | narrow connector     |  |
| <b>neck</b> (clothing)             | 領口                  | garment opening      |  |
| <b>V-neck</b>                      | V 領                 | neckline type        |  |
| <b>crew neck</b>                   | 圓領                  | neckline type        |  |
| <b>neckline</b>                    | 領口線                 | garment shape        |  |
| <b>bottleneck</b>                  | 瓶頸；阻礙               | limiting point       |  |
| <b>pain in the neck</b>            | 很煩的人 / 事            | annoyance            |  |
| <b>breathe down someone's neck</b> | 緊迫監督 / 催促           | close pressure       |  |
| <b>stick your neck out</b>         | 冒險挺身而出              | personal risk        |  |
| <b>risk your neck</b>              | 冒大險                 | danger               |  |
| <b>save someone's neck</b>         | 救某人一把               | avoid trouble        |  |
| <b>up to your neck in</b>          | 深陷於；忙到不可開交          | overwhelmed          |  |
| <b>neck and neck</b>               | 不相上下                | close competition    |  |
| <b>neck of the woods</b>           | 某個地區 / 一帶           | area                 |  |
| <b>get it in the neck</b>          | 被責罵 / 受罰            | criticism/punishment |  |

|                        |          |                  |  |
|------------------------|----------|------------------|--|
| **break your neck to** | 拼命做..... | extreme effort   |  |
| **neck** (verb)        | 親熱接吻     | romantic kissing |  |
| **necking**            | 親熱；擁吻    | noun/gerund      |  |

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### For your original sentence

> The deadline was \*\*breathing down our necks\*\*, so everyone was tired, tense, and a little irritable.

Here:

### \*\*breathing down our necks = 截止日期逼得很近，令我們感到強烈壓力\*\*

The literal image is:

> someone standing immediately behind you, close enough that you can feel their breath on your neck

The figurative meaning is:

> \*\*something or someone is pressuring you very closely and giving you almost no room to relax\*\*

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> \*\*截止日期已經逼在眼前 / 逼得我們喘不過氣\*\*，所以大家都很累、很緊張，也有點容易煩躁。

In this passage, \*\*「逼在眼前」\*\* is the cleanest translation, while \*\*「逼得我們喘不過氣」\*\* preserves more of the physical pressure in the English idiom.